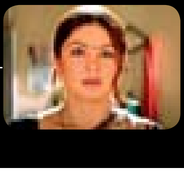
al fame today has been nothing less than spectacular. And yet, there's a certain humility that those who've worked with him point to. Shortly after the Oscar, when Bhatt congratulated Keeravani, all the latter had to say was this: "A feeling of personal pride floods me. I am very honoured. Thank you for the inspiration, Sir. Your words always make me think, emote and make me translate them into music." That evening, says Bhatt, the person the world saw on stage was very much the man he personally knew—"shy, of few words". Adds Bhatt, "He doesn't have the kind of flamboyance you see in this part of India... There is an explosive silence of the heart that you hear in his company. It is from where his music emanates. He comes from a school where you look at music as *saadhna*. The intent is not to numb or lull you to sleep, but to wake you up and make you soar."

The Best of Keeravani

Paccha Bottesi... (Telugu)
'Baahubali-1', 2015

- *Dheera Dheera* (Telugu) **'Magadheera'**, 2009
- *Antharyami alasithi solasithi...* (Telugu) **'Annamayya'**, 1997
- *Soundarya Lahari Swapna Sundari...* (Telugu) **'Pelli Sandhadi'**, 1996)
- *Em Pilladhi Yentha* (Telugu) **'Allari Priyudu'**, 1993
- *Tum Mile* (Hindi) **'Criminal'**, 1995
- *Yekkado Putti Yekkado Perigi* (Telugu) **'Student No. 1'**, 2001
- *Raalipoye Puvvaa neeku raagaalenhuke...* (Telugu) **'Matru Devo Bhava'**, 1993
- *Seethamma Andhaalu...* (Telugu) **'Subha Sankalpam'** 1995
- *Jaamu Rathiri Jaabilamma...* (Telugu) **'Kshana Kshanam'**, 1991
- *Kaliki Chilakalakoliki Maaku Menattha* (Telugu) **'Seetharamayya Gari Manavaralu'**, 1991
- *Gali Mein Aaj Chand Nikla* (Hindi) **Zakhm**, 1998



- *Awarapan Banjarapan* (Hindi) **Jism**, 2003

And 'Naatu Naatu' does exactly that. The peppy track from *RRR* (2022), directed by S.S. Rajamouli, who is also Keeravani's cousin, became a global sensation, being played in stadiums and clubs, with even BTS member Jung Kook grooving to it during a Weverse Live. It has garnered over 500 million views on YouTube, with many TikTok users even donning suspenders to attempt the smooth-as-butter footwork. It is, as actress Deepika Padukone said at the Oscars, "a total banger".

Keeravani has been Rajamouli's composer of choice for 21 years now, creating music for all 12 of his films, including blockbusters like *Eega* (2012) and *Baahubali* (2015 and 2017). "Working with Rajamouli is like writing notes without a pen and paper," Keeravani told US film website *IndieWire* last year. There's comfort and trust in the partnership, strengthened by his own familial connection and that of his wife, Srivalli, who is the sister of Rajamouli's wife, Rama (a costume designer on his films), and has also been a line producer on *Eega*, *Baahubali* and *RRR*. Keeravani is aware of both the pros and cons of working with family. "If he doesn't like something, he can yell at me like nothing because of the intimacy he has with me as a brother," he told the website *Awards Daily* recently.

Perhaps that rapport is partly what made 'Naatu Naatu' such a success. In multiple interviews, Keeravani has recalled how he came up with the melody in just 15 minutes and then went on to spoil Rajamouli with 20 different versions of the song. "I'm used to coming up with alternatives, thanks to my father, who made me work hard at constantly generating tunes when I was a child," he told *Variety* magazine in January. Rajamouli wanted a track that gave him "the satisfaction of a fight", he said. So, he met the brief by bringing in 'dafs', a percussion instrument used in folk music, to produce the beats and tempo. In addition, mandolins, oud and keyboards were also deployed. As for the lyrics, Chandrabose coined the phrase 'Naatu Naatu' in the car after meeting the composer.

It also helps that 'Naatu Naatu' was not just a thoughtless filler, but a powerful plot point in itself that pushes the narrative as the two protagonists—freedom fighters Ram (Ram Charan) and Bheem (Jr NTR)—rise to a terpsichorean battle against British colonists in their own garden. Keeravani roped in his son, Kaala Bhairava, along with Rahul Sipligunj, for the vocals, but both Rajamouli and he agree that it is Prem Rakshith's spectacular choreography that really sets 'Naatu Naatu' apart, and which earned their work a standing ovation at the Oscars.

JUST A BEGINNING

After a career spanning 33 years and composing music for hundreds of films, Keeravani has the world at his feet today. Backstage at the Academy Awards, soon after receiving the Oscar, he said, "I feel that this is just the beginning of everything, so that the world—particularly the West—focuses more on Indian music and Asian music, which is long due."

Ironically, nine years back, Keeravani's plan had been to retire: in 2014, he had declared that he would bid adieu to cinema on December 8, 2016, which would have marked 27 years of his being in the film industry after his first song on December 9, 1989, recorded at Chennai's Prasad Studios. Fortunately, he thought better of it. Otherwise, there would be no Oscar, no Padma Shri, no 'Naatu Naatu'. And the world would have been the poorer for it. ■